

THE TIME TRAVELER'S JOURNAL

Written by
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OVER PRODUCTION LOGOS

"Swiss Boy" by Lou Sern begins to play. It carries over into the first scene.

FADE IN:

EXT. SOUTHWEST DESERT - DAY

A vast desert landscape under a clear blue sky. Sand hills in the foreground give way to mountains in the distance. It's around noon.

After a few seconds, ARTHUR STERLING, a man in his late 20s wearing jeans and a dark gray denim jacket, appears out of thin air a few feet off the ground -- horizontal, facing down -- and promptly falls on his face.

ARTHUR
(groaning, sand on his
face)
Aw, hell... ow.

Arthur painfully gets to his feet and brushes off the sand, searching the ground. He finds a small music player half-buried nearby and picks it up -- the music is now coming from its tiny speaker. He switches it off, and "Swiss Boy" cuts out. He pockets it.

He looks around for a few seconds, then focuses on something a few yards away.

In the sand sits a perfectly black stone. It reflects no light at all, like a hole cut in reality. A small trail beside it suggests it rolled there.

ARTHUR (CONT'D)
(taking off his jacket)
There you are.

Arthur bends over the rock and cautiously drapes his jacket over it, careful not to touch it. He wraps it up and ties the sleeves together to hold it in place, then stands slowly, tying the bundle to his belt and getting a sense of his surroundings.

He starts walking toward the road and follows it east, glancing around. After a few seconds, he sticks out his thumb to hitchhike.

EXT. ROADSIDE DINER - DAY

A truck drops Arthur off in front of a small diner just off the main road. He waves goodbye to the driver as it rolls away.

Crossing the parking lot, he notices a red 1957 Chevy Bel Air convertible, top up, and lets out an impressed whistle. A heap of blankets fills its backseat.

ARTHUR

You seem a bit out of time. Like me.

He gives it a slight approving nod, then turns his attention to the diner. He eyes it for a moment before heading inside.

INT. DINER - CONTINUOUS

A bell above the door RINGS as Arthur enters. He walks up to the counter and leans on it, looking around for someone to talk to. A small sign reads: "TODAY'S SOUP: CHICKEN NOODLE -- FRIDAY SPECIAL."

He barely glances at it before catching the attention of the DINER LADY, an older woman in a yellow uniform.

DINER LADY

(dejected, walking over)

Welcome. What can I get you?

ARTHUR

Hi! I was just wondering if you had any extra boxes I could take off your hands? One about this big would be ideal.

Arthur shapes the size of the box with his hands, but she doesn't look.

DINER LADY

Yeah, I should. I can look in the back.

(under her breath)

Short a girl today, and now I'm hunting down boxes.

ARTHUR

Sweet, thanks!

She pushes through the kitchen doors. On the wall next to them hangs a simple month-and-day calendar: "JULY 12." Arthur pulls a small notebook from his back pocket.

ARTHUR (CONT'D)
(whispering to himself)
Friday the 12th...

He flips through the notebook, running his finger down the pages. After a few seconds, he stops on one entry and taps it a few times.

ARTHUR (CONT'D)
(looking up from the notebook)
1985... That makes the most sense.

He closes the notebook and slowly puts it away, lost in thought. He stares at the counter until the door bell RINGS behind him, snapping him out of it.

ARTHUR (CONT'D)
An entire year off...

The Diner Lady returns from the back holding a small cardboard box filled with packing peanuts.

DINER LADY
This is all I've got.

She sets it on the counter.

DINER LADY (CONT'D)
Will that be all?

Arthur looks the box over and tests its sturdiness.

ARTHUR
Yes, thank you! This will work great.

DINER LADY
(walking away)
Mm-hmm.

She heads over to a pair of MEN IN BLACK SUITS and sunglasses who have just sat down at the far end of the counter. Meanwhile, Arthur carefully unwraps his jacket and drops the rock into the box.

The men speak with the Diner Lady. She nods, then points them toward Arthur. They get up and walk his way as Arthur, oblivious, folds the box's flaps together so it stays shut. He breathes a sigh of relief. It's secure.

He smiles, puts his jacket back on, picks up the box, and heads for the exit -- not paying attention -- and walks directly into the two suited men.

ARTHUR

Oh, sorry about that, I wasn't--

Arthur trails off as he gets a good look at them. They stare at each other for a moment.

ARTHUR (CONT'D)

Well, that was quick.

He gives a slight chuckle -- then shoves the box into the face of SUIT #2, knocking him off balance. SUIT #1 lunges for Arthur, but Arthur dodges and clumsily jumps over the counter, tumbling out of sight on the other side. The box is left sitting on the counter.

Suit #1 recovers from the failed grab and turns to the box. He leans in to take it -- just as Arthur pops up and grabs it too. Face to face, they play tug-of-war across the counter, knocking over dishes and a glass of ice water.

Everyone in the diner is watching now. Suit #2 gets back up, smoothly vaults the counter, and runs toward the struggling pair. Arthur sees him coming and lets go of the box, sending both of them falling backward -- Suit #1 into a booth, knocking over the table, and Arthur into the back counter, knocking over a coffee pot. Suit #2 charges right through the space where they used to be and slips on the spilled ice water.

Arthur grabs the coffee pot and hurries around the counter, stepping over the fallen suit. He rounds the corner to find Suit #1 getting up from the toppled table, still holding the box. Arthur splashes the coffee in his face. The man is taken by surprise, but ultimately unfazed.

ARTHUR (CONT'D)

(surprised)

I thought that'd be hotter.

So he throws the pot itself at the man's head. Suit #1 reels back, dropping the box directly into Arthur's waiting arms. With both men momentarily stunned, Arthur bolts out of the diner.

The Diner Lady comes out of the kitchen and stands over the two men sprawled on the floor.

DINER LADY

You guys are cleaning this up.

EXT. DINER PARKING LOT - CONTINUOUS

Arthur runs through the lot, box in hand, and speeds right past the Bel Air -- then stops and backs up toward it.

He stares at it for a beat. The DING of the diner door alerts him: the two suits are back on their feet and looking for him, guns drawn this time. Arthur ducks down behind the car. They didn't spot him.

The men make their way down the lot, methodically checking the space between each car, one at a time. Arthur shuffles quietly along the side of the Bel Air toward the front passenger door, but stumbles and scrapes his foot on the asphalt -- just loud enough for Suit #1 to barely hear.

Wide-eyed, Arthur looks around for an escape route. He glances at the box briefly, then shakes his head with a quick, dismissive snort, casting the idea aside. Next to the Bel Air is a lifted pickup. As the men get closer, Arthur squeezes underneath it just as they round the corner.

The men stare at the empty gap. Their expressions don't change. One notices a small piece of fabric poking out from under the truck and starts to bend down for a look --

-- when a WOMAN SCREAMS.

Near the diner door, a customer stares at the men and their drawn guns. Her scream has distracted them both. Arthur seizes the opportunity: he rolls out, jumps into the Bel Air, and hot-wires it in under twelve seconds.

The engine roars to life, and the radio blasts a rock song at full volume. Arthur slams the gas, drawing the men's attention. They raise their guns, but Arthur hastily and sloppily peels out of the space and heads for the main road before they can fire. The men put their guns away and hop into a black Land Cruiser to give chase.

EXT. DOWNTOWN STREETS - CONTINUOUS

Inside the Bel Air, Arthur turns the radio off. He's far from the smoothest driver, but he's put some real distance between himself and his pursuers, speeding through downtown and weaving through traffic.

The radio pops back on by itself, startling him. He slams it off again.

A sign reads: "HIGHWAY ENTRANCE -- 1 MILE." Arthur stays as far left as he can.

The Land Cruiser is closing in, engine roaring. It pulls up on Arthur's left and is about to ram him -- when Arthur suddenly swerves right, cuts across every lane, and just barely makes the on-ramp.

INT. BEL AIR - MOVING - CONTINUOUS

The Bel Air speeds down the highway.

ARTHUR
(grinning)
Yes! Ha!

He's gotten away. For now.

In the backseat, the heap of blankets rolls and falls to the floor with a soft THUD. From it emerges ASPEN SIPE, a young woman in her 20s with deep red hair, wearing the same yellow uniform as the Diner Lady. Having just woken up, she looks around, unable to fully open her eyes.

ASPEN
(mouthing, barely
audible)
M-- moving...?

She slowly sits up higher, waking bit by bit. Arthur can now see her in the rearview mirror. His smile vanishes, and mild panic sets in.

Aspen grows more and more alert until she finally locks eyes with Arthur in the mirror. They stare at each other.

ARTHUR
Uh, hi! I--

He's cut off by Aspen SCREAMING. She scrambles back into the seat, kicking him and whacking him with her pillow.

ARTHUR (CONT'D)
(blocking her hits)
Hey-- hey! Cut it out!

She doesn't cut it out. She hits him a couple more times, then stops.

ASPEN
Who are you? Get out of my car!

ARTHUR
My name is Arthur. I'm kind of in a situation here. I'm sorry, I didn't mean to... kidnap you.

ASPEN
Well, you did! Now stop!

ARTHUR
You see, I--

Red and blue lights begin to flash in the rearview mirror.
The police are here.

ARTHUR (CONT'D)
(under his breath)
Oh, just perfect.

Aspen notices and turns around. She bangs on the rear window to get the officers' attention, then sticks her head out the side window, waving her arms.

ASPEN
Help! I'm being kidnapped by a
crazy person!

ARTHUR
What are you doing?! Calm down!

ASPEN
Pull over!

Aspen keeps pelting Arthur with anything she can reach inside the car.

ARTHUR
Quit it! Do you want us to crash?

ASPEN
Stop, you lunatic!

Aspen grabs the cardboard box from the front passenger seat to throw at him -- but stops to inspect it instead.

ASPEN (CONT'D)
(muttering)
What the... what is this?

Arthur, already on edge, goes rigid.

ARTHUR
Hey! Put that down! You don't want
to mess with that--

As if things couldn't get any worse: up ahead in the distance, the black Land Cruiser is barreling down the highway from the opposite direction, straight toward the Bel Air.

ARTHUR (CONT'D)
Okay, how did they even get over
there?!

Aspen is lost in a trance, just holding the box. Slowly, she
moves to open it.

ASPEN
(whispering to herself)
It feels... familiar.

ARTHUR
Hey! Don't open that--

He catches her eye in the mirror and is immediately
concerned.

ARTHUR (CONT'D)
Are you okay?

A beat. Then -- BANG! The driver's side mirror is blown
clean off. The Land Cruiser is closing in, and they're
shooting. Arthur snaps back to the road and tenses. Aspen
doesn't react at all.

ARTHUR (CONT'D)
Jesus! What's with these guys?

Aspen opens the box all the way and looks at the pitch-black
void inside. She stares at it for a moment before looking
back up at Arthur.

ASPEN
What is it?

ARTHUR
Listen to me. I can explain
everything, I just need you to put
that down. It's dangerous, and--

BANG! Another shot shatters the rear driver's side window.
Both of them react this time.

ASPEN
Who are THEY?

ARTHUR
A real pain, is who! Now give me
the box!

Arthur reaches back to grab it, but Aspen won't let go.

ASPEN
No! Let go!

ARTHUR

You let go!

Another BANG -- the front tire blows out, and police backup is closing in from behind. The Bel Air jerks violently, switching the radio on again: "Somebody to Love" by Jefferson Airplane blasts through the cabin.

Arthur barely keeps control of the car as Aspen and the box are flung over the seat into the front.

Arthur grabs the box and looks inside. It's empty. He immediately starts searching the car.

ARTHUR (CONT'D)

Don't move! Be very careful...
Where is it...

Aspen manages to sit upright and starts looking around with him.

ASPEN

What are we looking for?

ARTHUR

The black rock...

Aspen looks down at her hands, then holds them up for Arthur to see. She's cradling the stone, bare-handed.

ASPEN

Oh, I've got it, don't worry!

Arthur stares at her in shock.

ARTHUR

What the--

Before he can finish, the Land Cruiser appears on the passenger side and RAMS the Bel Air, sending it into a spin. The force sends Aspen sliding across the seat, straight into Arthur --

-- and the moment they touch, everything goes BLACK.

EXT. GRASS FIELD - NIGHT

The Bel Air is still spinning. After a few more rotations, it grinds to a stop. The radio is nothing but static now.

The two passengers just sit there side by side, breathing and calming down. It's dark outside, and the highway asphalt is now a grass field.

A beat. Arthur needs a moment to catch his breath. Aspen is simply in shock, staring out the windshield at their new surroundings. The world brightens slightly as an overhead street lamp flickers on.

Aspen stumbles out of the car and almost falls, catching herself on the door. She takes a second to regain her balance, then staggers a few steps away. Arthur notices and quickly gets out as well.

ARTHUR

Hey! Where are you going?

Aspen doesn't respond. She just takes a couple more steps. Arthur follows her.

ARTHUR (CONT'D)

Listen, we need to--

Aspen spins around and shushes him. Eyes closed, she takes a breath and composes herself. Then she opens them and stares at Arthur.

ASPEN

(exasperated)

WHAT'S GOING ON?!

Her expression is stressed but determined, and she stares him down even harder. Arthur raises his hands slightly, like a lion tamer, and speaks calmly.

ARTHUR

We've traveled. Now, I don't know where, but we're in a dangerous situation.

ASPEN

WE are in a dangerous situation?
You KIDNAPPED me! I'M the one in a dangerous situation!

ARTHUR

I didn't know you were back there!
I'm not happy about this situation either!

ASPEN

Okay, then take me home!

ARTHUR

I will!

A beat.

ARTHUR (CONT'D)
I will... soon. I can't yet.

Aspen throws her head back and laughs.

ASPEN
Ha! I knew it. You kidnapped me.
You know my ransom isn't worth a
lot, right?

ARTHUR
I wouldn't even know who to contact
for your ransom. Look, jumping is
dangerous. It takes tons of
concentration to work properly, or
you'll end up in another time and--

ASPEN
Another time?

Aspen stares in disbelief. Arthur places his hands on his
hips and sighs.

ARTHUR
Yes. Another time.

Aspen's shock shifts into a smile, and she's laughing again.

ASPEN
Oh man, you really ARE crazy! I
mean, I figured already...

She gestures to all of him.

ASPEN (CONT'D)
But I mean REALLY crazy. Like,
genuinely.

Arthur rubs his temples, drags a hand down his face, then
claps once.

ARTHUR
Okay! Do you want to go home?

ASPEN
What do you think?!

ARTHUR
Okay. Then I need you to trust me.

Now it's Aspen's turn to bury her head in her hands. She
begins pacing.

ASPEN
(whispering to herself)
This isn't happening, this isn't
happening...

Arthur watches her go back and forth.

ARTHUR
We just need to grab the rock and--

His expression suddenly changes. Alert now, he whips his head around, scanning the area. He spots the rock in the grass about thirty feet away and walks over, taking off his jacket. Aspen notices, breaks from her pacing, and follows.

Arthur crouches and wraps his jacket around the rock, as carefully as before. He stands slowly, holding it secure. Aspen stares at it and tilts her head for a beat.

ASPEN
What is it?

Arthur looks just past her. Visible now is a small row of buildings along a road. A sign on one of them reads: "24 HOUR COFFEE."

ARTHUR
Do you want some coffee?

INT. COFFEE SHOP - MOMENTS LATER